

How Do You Fix Data This Messy?

Two null rows, six merged fields, and no usable headers. Meet Power Query - nine deliberate steps that turn this panic into a clean, sortable table.

9

TRANSFORM STEPS

10

FINAL COLUMNS

0

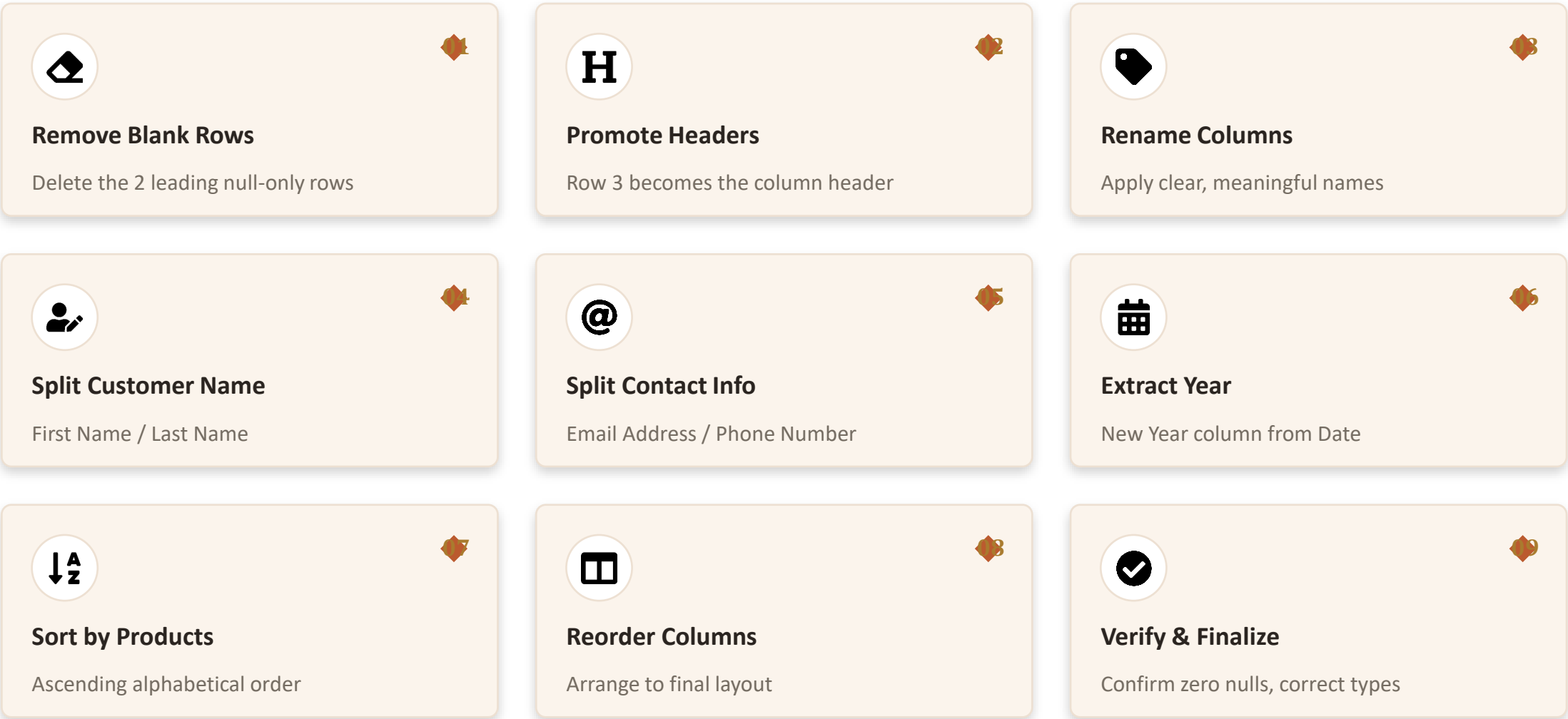
NULL ROWS REMAINING



Mood: messy data.

The Transformation Workflow

Nine sequential Power Query steps turn a messy spreadsheet import into a validated, sortable, reporting-ready table.



◆ STEP 00 • STARTING POINT

An Unusable Raw Export

◆ Generic Headers

Columns load as Column4 - Column9; the real field names sit buried in row 4.

◆ Two Blank Rows

Rows 2 and 3 are entirely null and carry no analytical value.

◆ Combined Fields

Contact Info and Customer Name each pack two data points into one cell.

Source[[Item="Customer Data",Kind="Sheet"]][Data]					
Column4	Column5	Column6	Column7	Column8	Column9
Valid 99% Error 0% Empty < 1%	Valid 99% Error 0% Empty < 1%	Valid 99% Error 0% Empty < 1%	Valid 99% Error 0% Empty < 1%	Valid 99% Error 0% Empty < 1%	Valid 99% Error 0% Empty < 1%
Column 4	Column 5	Column 6	Column 7	Column 8	Column 9
	null	null	null	null	null
	null	null	null	null	null
Contact Info	Products	Quantity	Price Per Unit	Total Price	Date
kupkac2@usatoday.com,997 870 6776	Cycling Gloves		2 \$800	\$1600	5/21/2015
imannr@paginegialle.it,849 214 8350	Bag of Trail Mix		2 \$250	\$500	3/16/2012
okieltf0@yellowpages.com,437 983 6077	Barbecue Grill		1 \$1200	\$1200	8/2/2014
bygraves1d@macromedia.com,978 484 2555	Body Wash		6 \$150	\$900	12/20/2015
hudleston4r@flavors.me,125 759 2045	Coffee Beans		3 \$275	\$825	9/4/2014
ding7u@ning.com,911 897 2612	Beard Trimmer		3 \$250	\$750	12/6/2013
deniset5u@hibu.com,262 132 4765	Carton of Eggs		4 \$150	\$600	8/4/2013
waby6w@businessweek.com,202 136 3866	Basketball		2 \$800	\$1600	12/23/2012
ivellender4g@ameblo.jp,770 947 5473	Chocolate Milk		4 \$125	\$500	10/4/2014
gouldthorpe8@xrea.com,370 697 0375	Condiments Set		4 \$150	\$600	8/14/2015
ipatten9o@reuters.com,704 721 7775	Breath Mints		1 \$700	\$700	9/17/2014
idagless82@opensource.org,764 190 8412	Bird Feeder		1 \$900	\$900	6/27/2014
wylemangz@tripod.com,454 450 3482	Closet Organizer		2 \$650	\$1300	11/7/2012
imatusevich1w@admin.ch,335 520 7564	Camping Tent		1 \$1200	\$1200	11/20/2015
iraulincc@etsy.com,185 378 0378	Desktop Computer		6 \$75	\$450	11/12/2013
geraultix@samsung.com,615 693 6495	Clock Radio		2 \$400	\$800	2/4/2015



Net Result

A clean starting point for the 9 transform steps that follow.

◆ STEP 01-02 • STRUCTURE

Remove Rows & Promote Headers

Home → Remove Rows → Remove Top Rows (2), then Use First Row as Headers to promote the real field names.



Remove Top Rows

Remove Top Rows

Specify how many rows to remove from the top.

Number of rows

OK

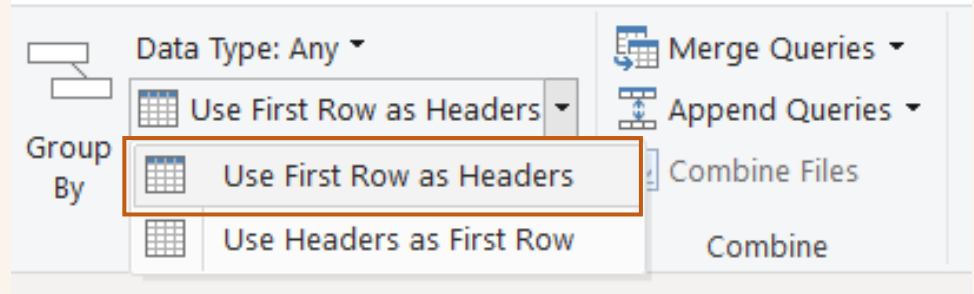
Cancel

2 rows removed- both were entirely null.



Use First Row as Headers

Transform tab → Use First Row as Headers



Row 3 (Contact Info, Products, Quantity...) is promoted to become the header row.

◆ STEP 04 · COLUMN SPLIT

Splitting Customer Name

Transform → Split Column → By Delimiter

Delimiter: Space, split at the left-most occurrence.



First Name

Text before the space delimiter



Last Name

Text after the space delimiter

Split Column by Delimiter

Specify the delimiter used to split the text column.

Select or enter delimiter

Space

Split at

- ☒ Left-most delimiter
☐ Right-most delimiter
☐ Each occurrence of the delimiter

▸ Advanced options

Quote Character

"

☐ Split using special characters

Insert special character

OK

Cancel

◆ STEP 05 • COLUMN SPLIT

Splitting Contact Info

Transform → Split Column → By Delimiter

Delimiter: Comma, split at the left-most occurrence.



Email Address

Text before the comma delimiter



Phone Number

Text after the comma delimiter

Split Column by Delimiter

Specify the delimiter used to split the text column.

Select or enter delimiter

Comma

Split at

- ☒ Left-most delimiter
☐ Right-most delimiter
☐ Each occurrence of the delimiter

▸ Advanced options

Quote Character

"

☐ Split using special characters

Insert special character

OK

Cancel

◆ STEP 06 · DATE INTELLIGENCE

Extracting the Year

Select the Date column

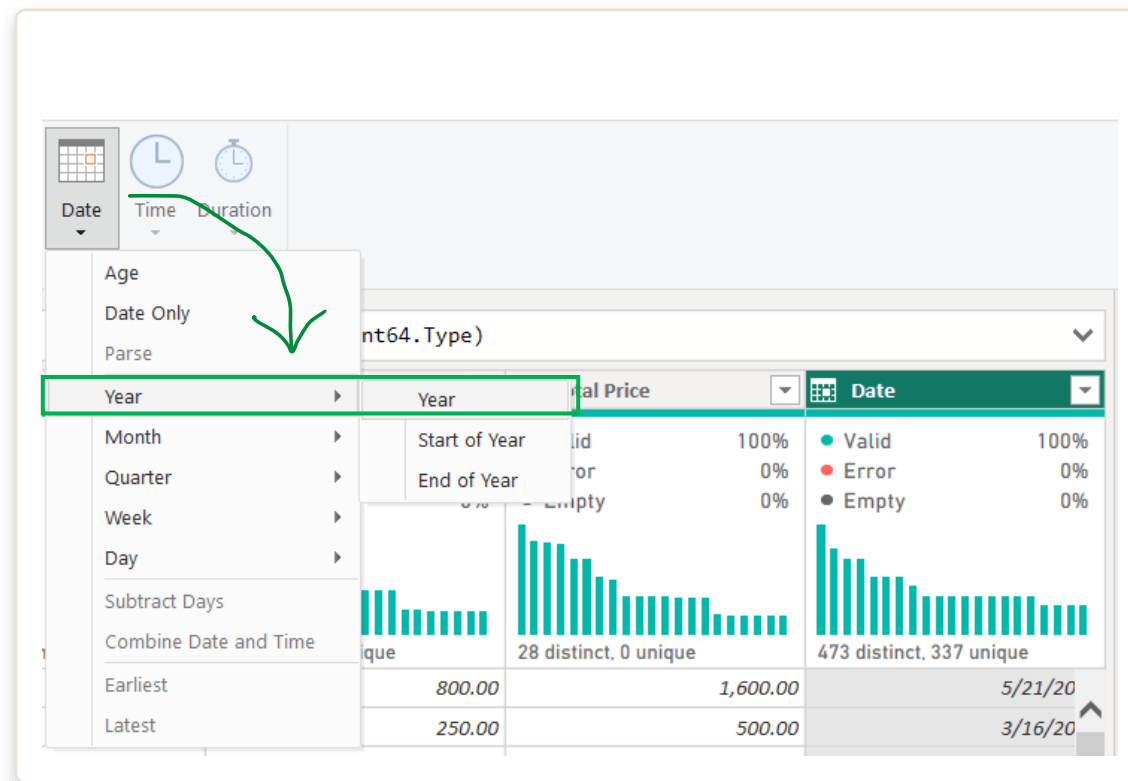
Add Column → Date → Year → Year

Power Query reads each Date value and generates a new Year column, giving the table a ready-made field for time-based grouping and reporting.



New Column: Year

5 distinct values · derived directly from Date, 0 errors.



◆ STEP 07-09 • FINAL STRUCTURE

Sort, Reorder & Trim the Table

With every field split and typed correctly, the table is put into its final reporting shape.



Sort Ascending

Table sorted by the Products column, A → Z, so related items group together.



Reorder Columns

Order ID, First/Last Name, Address, Email, Phone, Products, Quantity, Price, Total, Date, Year.



Remove Extras

Any leftover blank rows or helper columns are cleared from the query.

◆ STEP 10 · QUALITY CHECK

The Final, Verified Dataset

Column-quality view confirms 100% valid values across every field - no errors, no empties, table is ready for the analysis.

